

Grid-Down: Your First 72 Hours

The No-Panic Checklist

When the power's out and the internet's down, panic wastes the hours that matter most. Work these in order — water and warmth before comfort, always. Print it, check the boxes, and keep a copy with your supplies where the whole household can find it.

First 30 Minutes

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| ☐ | Stay calm and note the exact time the power dropped. |
| ☐ | Confirm the scope — is it just your breaker, or the neighborhood? (Check the panel, then neighbors.) |
| ☐ | Get everyone accounted for and set a household meeting spot. |
| ☐ | Grab headlamps/flashlights first — not open-flame candles. |
| ☐ | Put phones on low-power mode; pick ONE as the household comms phone. |
| ☐ | Leave the fridge and freezer closed. |

Water — Your Most Urgent Need

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| ☐ | Store water NOW while pressure holds: fill the bathtub, pots, and every clean container (a WaterBOB is ideal). |
| ☐ | Plan 1 gallon per person per day (drink + hygiene). Three-day minimum = 3 gallons per person. |
| ☐ | Know one treatment method cold: filter, then boil 1 minute (3 minutes above ~6,500 ft), or chemically treat. |
| ☐ | On a well? No power means no pump — draw from stored water first. |

Light & Power

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| ☐ | One light per occupied room; ration batteries. Keep spares in a known spot. |
| ☐ | Charge power banks for the comms phone; the car is a backup charger. |
| ☐ | Generator: OUTSIDE only, at least 20 ft from windows and doors. Never in a home, garage, or porch — carbon monoxide kills. |
| ☐ | Note anything that must stay cold (e.g., insulin) and plan a cooler. |



Heat & Shelter (Cold-Weather Outage)

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- Pick ONE room to keep warm; close it off and block drafts under doors.
- Layer clothing and share body heat; sleeping bags beat thermostats.
- Use only safe heat. Never run a gas stove, oven, or charcoal indoors for warmth.
- Wood stove or fireplace: crack a window for combustion air, and keep a CO detector running.

Food

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- Eat from the fridge first (~4 hours safe), then the freezer (~48 hrs if full, 24 if half), then the pantry.
- Keep freezer/fridge doors shut — a full freezer holds cold far longer.
- Start with no-cook foods; ration if the outage looks long.
- Keep a manual can opener with your supplies.

Medical

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- Locate your first-aid kit and every family member's medications.
- Refrigerated meds: move to a cooler with ice or packs.
- Know how to control bleeding (firm direct pressure; tourniquet high-and-tight for a limb) and treat for shock.
- This checklist supplements — it does not replace — professional care whenever it can be reached.

Communications & Information

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- Battery or hand-crank radio for NOAA weather and local AM broadcasts.
- If cell works, text instead of calling — it uses far less network.
- Set a family plan: one out-of-area contact everyone checks in with.
- Running two-way radios? Use a 3-3-3 plan: check channel 3, every 3 hours, for 3 minutes.

Security & Sanitation

- ☐ Lock up; keep light and noise low at night so you don't advertise that you have power or supplies.
- ☐ Agree now with trusted neighbors to watch out for each other.
- ☐ If water is off, don't flush freely — pour-flush with stored/gray water, or set up a lined bucket toilet with cover material (sawdust or kitty litter).
- ☐ Hand sanitizer and wipes prevent the illness that spreads fast when plumbing is down.

Documents & Cash (Grab-and-Go)

- ☐ Keep a folder with IDs, insurance, a medication list, and emergency contacts.
- ☐ Hold some cash in small bills — card readers and ATMs go down with the grid.

The Core 72-Hour Grab List

- Water: 3 gal/person
- Flashlights + batteries
- Medications
- Power bank(s)
- Manual can opener
- Whistle
- Sanitation/hygiene kit
- 3 days no-cook food
- First-aid kit
- Weather/AM radio
- Lighter & matches
- Cash (small bills)
- Warm blankets
- Copies of documents

Keep the whole playbook where the grid can't reach it.

This checklist is the first hour. The GridDownData vault carries field-tested guides for water, medical, power, food, shelter, and comms on an air-gapped USB drive that works with no signal and no power. Start with the \$24 Blueprint: griddowndata.com/blueprint

Educational reference material. For medical, structural, or legal decisions, consult a qualified professional whenever one is reachable. © 2026 GridDownData.